Ford Motor Company

James P. Vondale, Director
Automotive Safety Office
Environmental & Safety Engineering

April 3, 2001

Mr. Kenneth N. Weinstein
Associate Administrator for Safety Assurance
National Highway Traffic Safety Administration
400 Seventh Street, S.W.
Washington, D.C. 20590

Dear Mr. Weinstein:

Re: Ford Recall No. 01S15 -- 1999-2000 Model Year SVT Mustang Cobra and 2000 Model Year SVT Mustang Cobra R -- Rear Knuckle Replacement

Summary

- Ford Action -- Ford is conducting a voluntary safety recall involving the rear suspension knuckle on 1999 and 2000 model year SVT Mustang Cobra and 2000 model year SVT Mustang Cobra R passenger cars. These vehicles were built from November 2, 1998 through August 28, 2000.

- Number of Vehicles Involved -- Approximately 8,500 vehicles (8,100 in the United States, 250 in Canada and the remainder in Australia, Japan and other export markets).

- Affect on Vehicle Operation -- In certain aggressive driving cycles, the ball joint assembly in the rear knuckle where the lower control arm attaches is displaced longitudinally from its installed position, causing higher stress levels in the knuckle casting. If this occurs the casting may fracture, the corner of the vehicle may drop and the lower control arm may contact the inside of the rear wheel. In some cases directional control of the vehicle may be reduced. Ford is aware of 6 reports of fractured rear suspension knuckle castings and 15 reports of ball joint displacement without fracture. None of the reports allege that a fire, accident, injury or fatality occurred.

- Service Procedure -- Dealers will replace both rear suspension knuckles in the affected vehicles.

Attached is the detailed information required by the applicable portions of 49 CFR Part 573 -- Defect and Non-Compliance Information Report.

Sincerely,

James P. Vondale
Attachment
01S15 5d/rjw/tab

ATTACHMENT

49 CFR Part 573 – DEFECT INFORMATION REPORT
01S15 – 1999-2000 MODEL YEAR SVT MUSTANG COBRA AND 2000 MODEL YEAR SVT MUSTANG COBRA R – REAR SUSPENSION KNUCKLE REPLACEMENT

Pursuant to Part 573 of Title 49 of the Code of Federal Regulations, Defect and Noncompliance Reports, Ford Motor Company submits the following information concerning a safety recall action that it is voluntarily initiating.

573.5 (c) (2) -- Potentially Affected Vehicles

Certain 1999-2000 model year Ford SVT Mustang Cobra and certain 2000 model year SVT Mustang Cobra R passenger cars built at the Dearborn Assembly Plant from November 2, 1998 through August 28, 2000 are potentially affected.

Because these vehicles are not produced in VIN order, information as to the applicability of this action to specific vehicles can best be obtained by either calling Ford's toll-free line (1-800-392-3673) or contacting a local Ford dealer, who can obtain specific information regarding the vehicles from the Ford On-line Automotive Service Information System (OASIS) database.

573.5 (c) (3) -- Estimated Population of Vehicles Potentially Affected

Approximately 8,500 vehicles.

573.5 (c) (4) -- Estimated Percentage of Affected Vehicles with the Defect Condition

Unknown.

573.5 (c) (5) -- Description of the Defect

When operated in certain severe drive cycles (particularly those including frequent drag race type standing start acceleration) the ball joint in the rear suspension knuckle where the lower control arm attaches may be displaced longitudinally out of its installed position. If this occurs, the stress levels in the knuckle casting will increase and the casting may fracture. The corner of the vehicle will then drop and the lower control arm may contact the inside of the wheel. In some cases directional control of the vehicle may be affected.

As of March 15, 2001, Ford is aware of 6 reports of fractured rear suspension knuckle castings and 15 reports of ball joint displacement without fracture. None of the reports allege that a fire, accident, injury or fatality occurred.

573.5 (c) (6) -- Chronology of Events

Ford first became aware of reports of this condition during September 2000. Initial testing was conducted and verified that movement of the ball joint could occur if the minimum fit conditions were present between the knuckle casting and the ball joint. However, the total population of minimum fit parts was estimated to be only 20 parts. Further testing was conducted to determine whether any additional occurrences were likely, since the number of reports was approximately the same as the estimated number of minimum fit parts. Recent testing has confirmed that certain severe operating conditions (frequent drag race style standing start accelerations) can cause a displacement on parts with a nominal fit condition.

573.5 (c) (8) -- Service Program

Ford will notify owners of record of affected vehicles to return vehicles to dealers for installation of revised rear suspension knuckle assemblies with positive retention of the ball joint. This service will be performed at no charge to owners. Ford currently anticipates that owner notification will occur on or before the week of April 30, 2001.

573.5 (c) (9) -- Press statement and Dealer/Owner Letters

Ford does not plan to make a public statement concerning this action. Notices to dealers and owners from Ford Customer Service Division will be forwarded when available.

573.5 (c) (11) -- Recall Number

Ford has assigned recall number 01S15 to this action.